



MASQUERADE MURDER

THE COUNTESS
CHARACTER GUIDE
(4 - 8 players)



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THE COUNTESS

Masquerade Mystery

The year is 1755 and it's Carnival season in Venice, time for the masquerade ball.

A chance for rich and poor, old, and young to come together; everyone to be equal for a night. But when everyone is hiding their identity, it can be hard to know who you are talking to.

The question on everyone's lips is who is the figure in red? Seen conversing with several guests but no one admits to knowing them.

A glass smashes and the figure is found dead on the floor.

Who were they? And why did someone want them dead? It's your job to find out...



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THE COUNTESS

CHARACTER GUIDE

CHARACTER DESCRIPTION:

Female, Party host. Every year, she hosts a masquerade ball for all her rich society friends. She's a wealthy widow; her husband was the Governor of Venice for 20 years until his death last year. She's the social queen with the power to make or break your reputation. She has a say on everything including what's fashionable to wear, what foods to serve guests and who you should marry. No one in Venice can do anything without her permission and social ruin usually awaits anyone who challenges her authority.

SPOILER ALERT!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST STARTS THE GAME!

THE COUNTESS

ROUND 1

GETTING TO KNOW THE PLAYERS

INTROS

SAY HELLO!

Read this text word-for-word or paraphrase it in your own words as you introduce yourself to everyone. Don't add any information, just slang or casual language suitable for your character.

Greetings everyone I am The Countess. This is my party and so you all know me already. My husband was the Governor of Venice for 20 years until his death, God rest his soul. I had hoped my son would run for office but sadly he is no longer with us either. Now I spend my days hosting parties and dinners, deciding what and who is in fashion and making sure the season goes to plan. I make all the decisions around here, no one can even breath without my knowing of it. You need my approval to do anything around here, so it is best to stay on my good side.

YOUR RELATIONSHIP WITH THE VICTIM

All the Players have a history with the victim. Try to keep the details of your relationship to yourself—but be aware that other people may already have some idea of it!

Knew him when he was still respected, he was a friend of your son. While they were travelling together, your son got into a horse-riding accident that resulted in his death. Red Cloak was supposed to be looking after him. You were the one that cast him out of society in the first place because you blame him for your son's death.

STOP!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST INSTRUCTS YOU TO!

THE COUNTESS

ROUND 1

GETTING TO KNOW THE PLAYERS

RUMOURS

CHOOSE YOUR VICTIM

Here are things you may have observed about other characters. In your group, agree on a character you want to talk about—someone who is at the party, but preferably not within earshot.

THE DRAGON

Red Cloak was calling on his sister a lot last year and was seen dancing at the winter ball but then suddenly he stopped. The sister was moved to their other house outside of Venice after that.

THE LION

Red Cloak was often seen at parties and theatres with The General's son. Even The General seemed to like him and promoted his work. That stopped suddenly after the summer ball.

THE STALLION

Used to hang out a lot with Red Cloak. They were friends and would often brag to each other about their conquests. This stopped after the summer ball when he danced a lot with his sister. Did something more happen there?

THE SHARK

Appealed to The Governor for Red Cloak to be arrested for immoral behaviour and severe misconduct but he never was.

THE BLACK SWAN

Was heard saying to Red Cloak this evening, "You'll not get another penny from me until you find someone suitable."

THE BLUEBIRD

She announced her engagement to Red Cloak at the summer ball. The engagement was broken off not long after.

THE MOUSE

Father was killed in a duel a few years ago. Word on the street was that it was against Red Cloak.

THE PHOENIX

Has a secret child – some rich gent knocked her up and refused to marry her, so she left Venice in disgrace.

THE DOG

Was overheard talking to Red Cloak earlier and saying, "How could you do this to her? Hasn't she suffered enough?"

THE STAG

Was heard saying to Red Cloak this evening, "She was in Venice all this time and you kept it from me? What do I pay you for?"

THE CAT

Overheard saying to Red Cloak, "I should kill you for what you've done to my family. That money was all we had!"

THE HARE

Overheard talking to Red Cloak this evening saying, "I'll kill you myself if you even dare think of telling The General."

THE UNICORN

Was engaged to Red Cloak not long after the spring ball but called it off quite suddenly; it left her quite broken up, she nearly died of grief.

THE TURTLE

Very close with The Unicorn and threatened Red Cloak to a duel over her honour and heart ache.

THE SPARROW

Paid Red Cloak to accompany her to a few dances because she couldn't get a date any other way.

THE DOVE

Was in love with Red Cloak, they were supposed to get engaged, she was talking about it at the winter ball, but it never happened.

THE WOLF

Was heard saying to Red Cloak, "The plan has changed. I need my money back."

THE FOX

Was nothing but a farmer's son, but then suddenly, acquired a lot of wealth under very suspicious circumstances.

THE WEASEL

Was seen talking to Red Cloak, he handed him a bag of gold and hurried away.

SPREAD THE DIRT

Use your improvisational skills to share your rumour about that character with everyone in your group. Just as in real life, some people will already know your dirt—that doesn't mean you can't talk about it! The Host may ask you to move on to a different group, to share rumours with and about new people. Feel free to pass on or combine items you've heard from other Players. The Host may end the Round before you have finished, so get to the juicy stuff early!

BITE YOUR TONGUE!

If you hear someone spreading a rumour about you, pay attention but don't feel you need to answer. You'll have a chance to respond in the next Round.

STOP!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST INSTRUCTS YOU TO!

THE COUNTESS

ROUND 2

MOTIVES

Every Player answers ONE question posed by another character. Ignore any references to characters who are not at this party.

QUESTIONS TO ASK THE OTHER CHARACTERS

When it is your turn, choose ONE question to ask another Player and read it aloud.

Eventually, all the characters listed in that row will be asked that same question.

ASK: THE BLACK SWAN | THE CAT | THE WEASEL

"Scout Potential matches" sounds like a desperate cry for marriage. Financial security isn't an issue for some people here, but it is for you. Did you pay Red Cloak to help find a wealthy spouse?

ASK: THE STAG

Did you pay Red Cloak to find someone for you? Who was in Venice "all this time"?

ASK: THE STALLION | THE DRAGON

Red Cloak was seen at previous parties paying a lot of attention to your sister. Was there something going on there that you really didn't like?

ASK: THE LION

What happened to make you quite suddenly and publicly withdraw your support and funding for Red Cloak?

ASK: THE DOVE | THE BLUEBIRD | THE UNICORN

You were in love with Red Cloak once, weren't you? Did he break your heart too? He seems to have done that to a lot of people.

ASK: THE SPARROW

"Attend the Social" – it is fairly clear that that relates to you. Did you pay Red Cloak to accompany you to some dances?

ASK: THE HARE

What didn't you want Red Cloak to tell The General?

ASK: THE MOUSE | THE TURTLE

"Challenge to a duel." You are one of the few people here with a known history of duelling. Did you want Red Cloak to challenge someone?

ASK: THE PHOENIX

Rumour has it that you left Venice because you have an illegitimate child. Was Red Cloak the father?

ASK: THE WOLF

What plans changed? Was it you who asked Red Cloak to find "suitable lodgings?"

ASK: THE FOX

Red Cloak had a reputation for dirty dealing. Did he help you gain your wealth? A simple farmer's son would not normally achieve the fortune you have.

ASK: THE SHARK

You appealed for Red Cloak's arrest many times. Why?

ASK: THE DOG

Who were you referring to when you spoke to Red Cloak earlier? Who's suffered enough?

**ANSWERS FOR
WHEN YOU ARE
QUESTIONED**

When another Player asks you, read the appropriate answer.

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT

Red Cloak was not welcome here. My son was good friends with him, trusted him a bit too much and it cost him his life, but we are civilized company. My house is open to the best of Venetian society. Only the most elite and respected members of the gentry can be seen here. Red Cloak may have the look of a gentleman and the charm and talent of one, but he was not one and he was banished. Nothing more.

IF YOU ARE GUILTY

Red Cloak was not welcome here. My son was good friends with him, trusted him a bit too much and it cost him his life, but we are civilized company. My house is open to the best of Venetian society. Only the most elite and respected members of the gentry can be seen here. Red Cloak may have the look of a gentleman and the charm and talent of one, but he was not one and he was banished for his crimes. If he came back into a house full of his enemies, I cannot be held responsible for what someone may do to him.

STOP!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST INSTRUCTS YOU TO!

THE COUNTESS

ROUND 3

METHOD

Every Player answers ONE question posed by another character. Ignore any references to characters who are not at this party.

QUESTIONS TO ASK THE OTHER CHARACTERS

When it is your turn, choose ONE question to ask another Player and read it aloud. Eventually, all the characters listed in that row will be asked that same question.

ASK: THE MOUSE

So, you blame Red Cloak for the death of your relative. Is that why you invited him here to kill him? Why poison though? Why not challenge him to a duel? It's a fair fight then.

ASK: THE STALLION | THE SHARK | THE DRAGON

Maybe the letter refers to Red Cloak's threats to your family's reputation? Had he succeeded in seducing your sister? That would make you want him dead, and poison is a very subtle way to kill someone.

ASK: THE BLACK SWAN | THE SPARROW | THE STAG

That letter is a definite threat. Did you decide to kill him tonight because he refused to give your money back for the job he failed to complete?

ASK: THE LION

I can imagine you being quite angry at Red Cloak. Had he succeeded in seducing your daughter? That would make you want to kill him.

ASK: THE DOVE | THE UNICORN | THE BLUEBIRD

Poison can be quite a painful way to die. The kind of pain you might want to inflict on someone who hurt you. Maybe his letter was trying to manipulate you into forgiving him, but you'd already decided to make him suffer?

ASK: THE PHOENIX | THE HARE | THE FOX

That letter just screams blackmail. You were one of the few people who Red Cloak could blackmail. Is that why you decided to poison him?

ASK: THE DOG | THE TURTLE

Red Cloak had hurt and threatened people that you care about. Maybe you decided to get justice on him for the way he treated them?

ASK: THE WEASEL

Did you decide to poison Red Cloak to get rid of him because he threatened to expose your secret? As a man of God that would certainly be a moral dilemma for you.

ASK: THE WOLF | THE CAT

You don't have a lot of money yourselves, yet you gave quite a bit to Red Cloak. Maybe you decided to kill him when he refused to give it back when you needed it?

**ANSWERS FOR
WHEN YOU ARE
QUESTIONED**

*When another Player asks you a question,
read the appropriate answer.*

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT

And who here would be willing to duel him in my name? For my honour? I don't have subjects, I'm not a Queen and my husband and son are both dead. It is well known Red Cloak was a master duellist. He has a fair amount of blood on his hands. He was a clever man though, I'm surprised poison got him, he certainly wouldn't take a drink from me so it would have to be someone he trusted, was close to you know.

IF YOU ARE GUILTY

And who here would be willing to duel him in my name? For my honour? I don't have subjects, I'm not a Queen and my husband and my son are both dead. It is well known Red Cloak was a master duellist. He has a fair amount of blood on his hands. Only a fool would challenge him. Poison however, that was clever.

STOP!
DO NOT CONTINUE UNTIL THE HOST INSTRUCTS YOU TO!

THE COUNTESS

ROUND 4

OPPORTUNITY

Every Player answers ONE question posed by another character. Ignore any references to characters who are not at this party.

QUESTIONS TO ASK THE OTHER CHARACTERS

When it is your turn, choose ONE question to ask another Player and read it aloud. Eventually, all the characters listed in that row will be asked that same question.

ASK: THE SPARROW | THE BLACK SWAN | THE WOLF | THE STAG

You hired Red Cloak to do a job for you, he failed, and you asked for your money back, but he didn't give it to you. Were you trying to play nice to get him to trust you so you could kill him?

ASK: THE MOUSE

It's clear that you were angry at Red Cloak; you blamed him for the death of your relative. It'd be quite easy for you to arrange to meet him somewhere to kill him. This is your house.

ASK: THE LION | THE DRAGON | THE STALLION | THE SHARK

Admit it; you wanted revenge on Red Cloak for trying to seduce your relative and nearly ruining your family's reputation. You care a lot about your position in society. Did you kill Red Cloak to protect your reputation?

ASK: THE HARE | THE PHOENIX | THE WEASEL | THE FOX

So Red Cloak found out things you didn't want anyone to know about. He was blackmailing you. It would make sense that you'd want to kill him for that. Did you trick him into meeting you here tonight?

ASK: THE TURTLE | THE DOG

You seek justice for the wrongs you feel have been done to the people you care about. Did you write that note to Red Cloak to draw him here to make him pay?

ASK: THE DOVE | THE UNICORN | THE BLUEBIRD

The note was written in an elegant hand. Female perhaps? They say "hell hath no fury like a woman scorned." Did you plan to poison Red Cloak tonight because he broke your heart?

ASK: THE CAT

A widow could hardly be a threat to him, so maybe Red Cloak thought he can get more money from you? Perhaps you saw his ulterior motive and wanted to trick him into coming here tonight so you could kill him?

**ANSWERS FOR
WHEN YOU ARE
QUESTIONED**

*When another Player asks you a question,
read the appropriate answer.*

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT

I don't blame him entirely, he had no quarrel with my family and I certainly never gave him any reason to dislike us to begin with, I knew he wasn't aristocracy but he was still respectable, or so I thought anyway. No, I blame whoever it was that hired him to kill my relative in a duel, this was their fault. Red Cloak was just stupid enough to take the contract. The consequences for that were being disgraced and banished. His return tonight has nothing to do with me.

IF YOU ARE GUILTY

I don't blame him entirely, he had no quarrel with my family and I certainly never gave him any reason to dislike us to begin with, I knew he wasn't aristocracy but he was still respectable, or so I thought anyway. No, I blame whoever it was that hired him to kill my relative in a duel, this was their fault. Red Cloak was just stupid enough to take the contract. The consequences for that were being disgraced and banished, he should have stayed away. His return tonight was his own fault and the price he paid was his life.

**DO YOU KNOW WHODUNIT?
TURN THE PAGE TO SHARE YOUR DEDUCTIONS**

THE COUNTESS

ACCUSATIONS OR VOTING

Follow the Host's instructions on how to name the Murderer.

- *You may fill out a Game Ballot on paper or via Chat.*
- *You may be asked to make an Accusation in the format below.*

Either way, the first Player to correctly identify the Murderer and motive wins the game. If nobody gets it right, the Murderer wins!

ACCUSATION FORMAT

I accuse _____ of murdering Red Cloak.

I believe their motive was:

OPTIONAL:

I base my accusation on this evidence:

THE COUNTESS

FINAL STATEMENTS

When the Host calls on your assigned letter, share the appropriate Final Statement:

IF YOU ARE INNOCENT

Red Cloak had a reputation for causing trouble, he was a brawling womanizer and a gambling drunk, it doesn't surprise me that someone killed him; he made a lot of enemies. But murder is beneath me. I had the power to banish him and after his conduct over the last few years I was quite willing to do that. My association with him ended there. He could have remained in exile and kept his life, it would have been safer for him to do that. But no, he came back and one of his many enemies took it upon themselves to get their revenge. I'm not sorry he's dead; it was his own fault, but his blood is not on my hands.

IF YOU ARE GUILTY

Yes, I killed Red Cloak; he's responsible for the death of my relative. He took a life so we took his life; a life for a life.

Red Cloak knew how important money and power is and he knew there would be consequences for going against me. It was made very clear when we banished him what would happen if he returned. He couldn't really expect me to just let it slide.

Arsenic is very easy to get hold of, it's found in everyday items. It's also invisible when added to liquid. The only clue might be an almond smell; however, one of my favourite foods is sugared almonds and there was a whole plate full of them on the terrace. Anyone would assume the smell came from there.

Red Cloak would recognise my hand, my writing looks elegant and reflects that of a respectable member of the aristocracy. And I knew Red Cloak would meet me as we still had so much unfinished business to discuss.

I made sure I'd spoken to the servants to bring two drinks of the finest wine out onto the terrace for me. While everyone was busy dancing in the main hall, no one noticed me slip the powder into the goblet. It only takes a few seconds for it to disappear in the liquid and so when Red Cloak joined me, and I was apologetic and full of smiles, he suspected nothing and took the drink.

Once he'd taken the first sip, I knew it'd only take a few minutes until it kicked in and so I claimed I needed to use the privy, told him to enjoy the drink and I'd be back in a few minutes and slipped quietly back into the hall.

I was in here when he actually collapsed, and I feigned surprise with everyone else when the death was announced.

He deserved what happened to him, there are consequences for going against me, Red Cloak learnt that tonight as will anyone else who disobeys my orders.

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